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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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by sting52

Summary

After finding Melog on Krytis, Catra begins to discover her true identity and history.

It all felt familiar yet off-putting, like a childhood that doesn't quite match memory. The brown trunks and green leaves were a shade too dark, her feet sunk an inch too deep into the moss, and the sky was filled with stars rather than darkness. The air smelled of moss freshly washed in rain, reminding her of the smell of the Whispering Woods, but stronger, more vibrant. Bow and Glimmer's voices cut through the background chirps and rustles of the forest of Krytis as they recounted the day's events to Entrapta and Wrong Hordak: getting lost in the ancient spire, magical booby traps, and Melog—the shapeshifting, teleporting alien cat, the planet's only survivor. Catra had hardly taken her eyes off them as she and Adora walked a few paces behind the rest, content in each other's silence.

"Hey, so, when you and Melog touched and everything was all glowy and the lights were all…"

Adora made a big face and explosive hand gesture. "What, uh, what was that all about?"

"I don't know," Catra said. "I'm still trying to figure it out."

She looked ahead at Melog, who walked next to Bow as he scratched their head. Catra's gaze was locked on their blue mane that seemed to disappear into the air as it swayed and glowed. Every second around Melog gave her a dozen new questions she needed answers to.

"When we touched, I saw all these flashes of their life here—but they weren't flashes, they were like feelings. Like I was feeling them, but not like I feel my feelings, like I was feeling them second-hand, " Catra continued. "It-it was weird. I can still kind of feel what they're feeling. I don't know. I don't get this magic stuff."

What was weirder to Catra was how okay she felt about the whole experience. Only a few days ago Horde Prime was rummaging around her mind, helping himself to her memories and thoughts and emotions while he used her body like a puppet. But Melog was different. Her thoughts and her mind were still hers, she just felt her emotions bouncing off of Melog's. And the feelings of Melog's life she had seen felt a lot like her own.

Melog left Bow's scratches and fell back to Catra and Adora.

“Catra,” they said. Catra jumped a little at hearing both her name and the voice. It was still weird hearing the cat speak their language. Their voice was deep but feminine.
“What’s it saying?” Adora asked. To her, Melog’s speech just sounded like reverbed meowing. Bow, Glimmer, Entrapta, and Wrong Hordak stopped to listen.
“It…says it needs to say goodbye…to its home,” Catra translated as Melog spoke to her. “It won’t take long. And…they want me to go with them.”
Catra looked from Melog’s eyes to Adora. Her emotions were written across her face.
“I’ll be fine,” Catra said.
“Are you sure?” Adora asked.
“Yeah. I…I want to go. There’s something about this place, about Melog, it feels…familiar. But I don’t understand any of it.”
“Go,” Bow said. “We’ll get the ship ready.”
“And we’ll be on comms if you need anything,” Glimmer added.
Catra gave them a smile and looked to Adora. “We’ll be back soon,” she said. She felt Melog’s head slide under her hand, and they vanished.
…….
Catra tried her best to look natural while cramped on the top shelf of the storage closet, wondering how much longer it would be before Adora barged in. This was one of her less common hiding spaces, and it gave her about an hour of brooding time while Adora ran around the Fright Zone checking her usual spots.
The door slammed open, and Adora walked in gasping for air. Catra kept her eyes on the ceiling, doing her best to look unphased by Adora’s arrival.
“I have run around…the entire Fright Zone looking for you,” Adora announced between breaths.
“You know nobody’s making you do that,” Catra replied. She knew not to fall for the anger Adora tried to put into her voice. She was far more proud of herself for finding Catra than she was angry at her for running off.
Adora jumped and flailed her legs while she pulled herself up to the shelf Catra was laying on. “Okay. Come on. Why’d you go all claws at Lani?”

“Because she was asking for it,” Catra said as if it was obvious. “I don’t know why she thought she could take me this time,” she muttered to the wall.
“You scratched her up pretty bad, Catra,” Adora said.
Catra finally looked at Adora. “Why is this my fault? Lani was being mean and wanted a fight so I gave her one. The only reason everyone’s upset is because I won.”
“You know she didn’t mean what she said.”
“She called me a freak, Adora. Maybe you should ask her, but it didn’t sound like she was just joking around.” Catra had discovered sarcasm recently, and now it was part of her everyday speech. She slid off the shelf, landed on all fours, and left the closet, hoping that would end the conversation and knowing it wouldn't. Adora shimmied and crashed to the ground, then ran to catch up.
“She was just trying to make you mad,” Adora said, still not giving up.
“Whatever. It’s fine,” Catra said to end the conversation. “She’s right anyway.”
Adora stopped in the middle of the hallway as if Catra had slapped her. “What does that mean? You’re not a freak!”
Catra stopped and let out a grunt. She hadn’t meant to say that out loud. She didn’t want to have this conversation, but she couldn’t admit she was wrong. “It’s fine. Can we just forget about this?”
This is why you keep those thoughts to yourself, Catra.
“You’re just different from us, Catra. That doesn’t make you a freak.”
“I’m not just different from you, Adora, I’m different from everyone. You all have each other, even Rohelio has a weird lizard family out there somewhere. But there’s no one else like me. I don’t have anyone.”
Adora paused as if Catra had given her a puzzle to solve instead of an angry rant. “Let’s ask Shadow Weaver! I’m sure she knows where you come from,” Adora said with a smile.
“Yeah, I’m sure she’d be happy to help out.”
“See, there you go-oh. Sarcasm. Right.” Adora stopped to think once more. “I know! Let’s just find them ourselves.”

“What?” Catra asked. Adora’s optimism never failed to confuse her.
“Your family has to be out there somewhere. Let’s go out and look for them.”
“So, you’re suggesting what, we sneak out and steal a skimmer to go looking for my cat-family who probably doesn’t even exist who could be anywhere on Etheria?”
“Yep,” Adora said.
Catra stopped to look at her. Adora’s dorky blue eyes were full of the same blind hope she’d seen for the past thirteen years.
“Okay,” Catra said.
…….
Catra felt her feet land on rock and her brain jump out of her skull.
“Your teleportation isn’t as bad as Glimmer’s, but…still not the best feeling,” she said. But she forgot about the headache as soon as she looked around. They stood on a cliff of a mountain looking over mountains and forests of deep emerald and teal that saturated the planet’s surface until the trees became dots on the horizon. The sun rose over the trees, giving pinkish-orange paint to the sky. It was night when they left; they must have teleported to a different side of the planet. That explained the headache. Catra had only seen the planet in moonlight, and the damp forest didn’t leave the best impression. But in the light, the planet’s beauty was undeniable. Horde Prime had done terrible damage to the planet, but the life and magic of Krytis had persevered.
She followed Melog through an entrance in the mountainside into a cave that felt like it existed in its own dimension. She heard nothing but her and Melog’s footsteps as she walked in. The cave looked about 30 meters deep, with rock walls arching high above them, lit by the flickering light of a fire in the back of the cave. Catra looked up at the wall to her right and saw a massive portrait of five cats, painted with crude but vibrant pigment. Each had the same maroon coat as Melog, but different color manes.
“My family”, Melog said, startling her. “My parents”, they said as they walked past two large cats with pink and purple manes, their poses making them look wise and stoic. “The ones who died saving me.”

Melog walked past their own portrait toward two smaller cats sporting yellow and orange manes. “And my siblings,” they continued. “The ones I could not save.”
Catra had no idea what she could say in response to that, so she just kept staring at the portraits. She turned to see more portraits filling the wall until it curved around the back of the cave - more families, more parents, more children. And Melog was the only one left.
She followed Melog across the cave, where there was a line of paintings all about three feet high off the ground. As she got closer, she saw each was a pair of cat ears, with a paw print beside each.
“When the kittens of our tribe came of age, they journeyed into the planet to touch our magic. When they returned, they pressed their ears and paws into this wall, showing they had become one with their home”, Melog explained, as if they had spent years rehearsing for the day they would get to show this to someone.
Catra dragged her hand across the wall, looking at each pair of ears. They all looked small, but they were all the same shape as the ears on her head.
“You’re confused. Do you still not understand?” Melog asked as if reading her mind. “You are connected to this place. This is your home.”
“Woah-“ Catra said, and stammered out a dozen sounds before she found words. “I-okay. No. I have cat ears. You have cat ears. I admit, that’s weird. But, in case you haven’t noticed, I come from a planet called Etheria, I’m not magic, I walk on two legs, and I don’t really look like you from the ears down.”
“You felt your connection to this place when we imprinted,” Melog continued, unphased by Catra’s rebuttal. “When we touched, I saw not just your heart and your mind, but your history. Would you like to know where you come from?”
Catra could do nothing except stare at Melog, her eyes wide, her heart’s jog turning into a sprint. Melog’s mane turned yellow.
“The First Ones came to our planet to explore and plunder our resources hundreds of years ago. They sought to understand—and eventually take—our magic. But they were not all so selfish and greedy. Before they began harvesting our magic, some

roamed our world with curiosity and wonder, and came to connect with our kind. Legend tells of our ancestors bonding and imprinting onto a First One, the first to ever imprint onto another kind.
"That First One carried a piece of our identity and magic with her when she left our planet. I can't see how, but you descend from this First One. You carry this world's magic inside you."
Catra felt her feet stumble back and her mouth move, but she couldn't hear what she was saying. Melog's words became an ocean that drowned her mind. Melog's mane was orange and moved like the flames of a fire.
"I-No. No. That's not possible. I'm not magic. I'm not special," she stammered.
Melog pressed their head into Catra's stomach, taking her off guard. She felt Melog's breath against her and put her hand on their head. The whirlwind in Catra's head slowed, and Melog's mane returned to a calm blue. Catra heard a soft purr as she scratched their head.
"Come," Melog said, stepping away from her and walking out of the cave.
"If we have to teleport again don't be mad if I vomit on your-"
Catra stopped to see Melog waiting on the cliff for her, having shapeshifted larger with two long wings stretching out from her sides.
"Orrrr we could fly. Yeah. That works too."
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"CAT PEOPLE! CALLING ALL CAT PEOPLE!" Adora yelled into Whispering Woods as their skiff coasted between trees.
"Would you shut up?" Catra hissed at her.
"What? They could be hiding somewhere, they should at least know we're looking for them," Adora replied.
Catra went to the back of the skimmer to sit and brood. She didn't understand how Adora could be so cheery through all of this. Since they woke up in the middle of the night to sneak out, Catra had been doing her best to hide how she was feeling - a skill she had mastered by now. Her breath was shallow and her heart wouldn't stop racing, but she kept her face relaxed and her hands still.

She couldn’t stop thinking of what might happen if they actually found these ‘cat people’. Would she find her parents? Were her parents alive? Would they accept her, would they want her, would she leave the Horde, would she leave Adora? She had spent the past two hours in a pit of questions that grew deeper and deeper, with no hope of an answer to pull herself out.
She finally stood and joined Adora at the helm.
“We should go back,” she said. “We’re not gonna see anything, and it’ll be morning soon.”
“Please, we have at least another hour,” Adora said without taking her eyes off the path ahead. She had never driven a skiff before, and her jerky steering had barely kept them alive.
“Adora-“ Catra paused to hold her frustration in. “We’ve been out here for two hours looking for cats who probably don’t exist and have never been seen before, and we’ve found nothing. And we’re not going to. This was a stupid idea.”
Adora stopped the skimmer so she could look at Catra. “But…we have to find them,” Adora said. Catra couldn’t stand to look at her wide blue eyes.
“Adora - we’re not going to find them. They’re not out there. They don’t exist. I don’t have people-“ she stopped herself when she heard her voice shake.
Just as Adora opened her mouth to reply, the trees above them shook. They looked up and saw the shaking leaves continue in a line going away from them - something had just run over top of them.
Adora’s puppy dog face turned into the face of an infinitely optimistic 13-year-old girl who had just found buried treasure.
“Catra! CAT PEOPLE!” she yelped as she squeezed Catra’s face. “Come on!”
“Adora-“ Catra started, knowing she wouldn’t have time to reply as Adora leaped out of the skimmer and ran through the forest. She sighed once, jumped out, and ran after her.
Adora didn’t slow down as Catra called after her while she sprinted through the woods to keep the shaking leaves in her sight. Adora ducked behind a bush, and Catra panted as she caught up to her.
“I didn’t see what it was, but I think it went in there,” Adora

whispered, pointing to a hole in a rock wall.
"Well it's probably a spider or monster or who knows what else lives in these woods-" Catra whispered.
"Orrrrr it's cat people!" Adora replied, cutting her off. Catra saw any hope for rationality was long gone.
"Fine. Let's go," Catra said. The background hums and rustles of the woods faded away as they walked into the cavern, the echo of their footsteps cutting through silence.
"Hey Catra," Adora whispered as the light behind them shrunk further away.
"Yeah?"
"You can see in the dark right?"
Catra focused her eyes, expanding her pupils so she could see with only the faint light trailing from the entrance behind them.
"Yeah," she said.
"Well, that means this would probably be a good spot for cat people to live," Adora whispered.
"Pretty sure there are other things that can see in the dark too," Catra whispered back. "Like monsters, and…that."
Catra looked up to see fifty eyes of a spider hanging five feet above them. She looked past the eyes to see a torso bigger than the two of them put together, and legs that stretched ten meters across the length of the cavern.
"What is it?" Adora whispered. "I can't see."
"Run."
Catra grabbed Adora's hand and sprinted towards the tunnel's entrance. She heard the movement of eight legs behind them, but she didn't look behind her. She could only run as fast as she could and keep Adora's hand in a death grip.
Adora's hand flew out of hers, and she turned to see the spider grab Adora's legs with two of its own, crawl across the wall onto the ceiling, and crawl back the way it came. Catra was sprinting again, willing her legs to go faster than they'd ever gone before, but the spider was still getting further from her. She gritted her teeth as she heard Adora cry out for her, jumped forward, and ran on all fours. She closed in on the spider, running until she was underneath it, leaped up, and slashed the creature's hide.
Adora and the spider crashed to the ground. Catra found her best

friend and pulled her up.
They ran toward the light, the only thing Adora could see, as they heard the spider get to its feet behind them. Catra was locked in on the light in front of them, thinking nothing but have to get Adora out have to get Adora out have to get-
And then she felt her tail whip back, pulling her to the ground. She felt bone wrap around her waist, and then she was flying through the air as the spider carried her back. She opened her eyes to see Adora blindly chasing after her.
"Adora, run!" She yelled out. "Just get out of here!" The only thing in the universe that mattered to Catra was running toward her death instead of away from it.
Adora didn't listen to her. She sprinted until she heard the spider's legs as loud as her own, then jumped forward and swung her arms forward hoping they would collide with something useful. They did. She grabbed onto a bony leg, jerked back and forth with it as it moved across the ground, and found her grip. She slowly crawled toward the sound of Catra's angry screams.
She found the fleshy mass of its torso. She started punching down at it; she didn't think it was doing anything but she had no idea what else to do.
"MOVE!", she heard Catra yell. She jumped and heard one of the spider's legs pierce its torso where Adora had just stood. Adora had a crazy idea - she grabbed the leg and jumped forward, wrapped her arms and legs around it, and plunged it into the spider's head.
The spider collapsed, sending Adora and Catra flying into the ground. Adora stood and heard Catra marching towards her.
"Why would you do that?" Catra yelled at her.
"Why did I save you?" Adora responded, confused.
"You could've died."
"Yeah, you could have too. And you saved me first, dummy."
"I would've been fine. You can't just risk your life for me like that," Catra snapped back, unamused.
"And why not?" Adora asked, her confusion turning to anger. "You did the same thing for me. Why can't I save you?"
Catra growled, angry at Adora and herself. She tugged at her hair and made another collection of angry sounds, then stormed off.

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Catra clung to Melog's fur as they soared through the sky. She was grateful for her short hair, the mane she had her whole life would have tied itself into a thousand knots in the wind. She looked at Melog's wings flapping rhythmically.
If a cat had wings, I guess that's what they'd look like.
She looked out to see the pink sun higher in the sky. The planet seemed to buzz with energy; the treetops glistened in the sunlight, and the river below them rushed through swaying trees. This place, and Melog, it all felt like an old memory that had slipped away. Melog's words replayed in her mind on a loop. Could what they said be true? Was this her home? Catra looked down to the forest and imagined herself running on all fours, climbing through trees, and snatching fish that jumped from the water. She realized that in her entire life, she had never thought about the Fright Zone like that - it was always just the miserable place that she lived in, she never imagined a future there.
Is this what home feels like?
But she couldn't be magic. Magic was for princesses, and Adora's buff alter ego, and alien cats, but not her. She wasn't born with some gift from the universe to make her better than everyone else. Everything she had done in her life she had fought for with her claws and her wit and nothing else.
But Melog had no reason to lie to her. Maybe this was her home. Maybe she could fit in here. Maybe she could be…magic.
No, you've never fit in anywhere, and you're not a magic princess. You can't let your guard down just because the alien cat you just met told you a fairy tale that makes you feel warm and fuzzy on the inside.
Catra sighed and laid her head on Melog's back as they coasted down to the ground. The voice in her head would always win. The hundreds of times she had thought of leaving the Horde, finding Adora, making amends, the voice was always there to remind her that she wasn't wanted, wasn't special, that she was all she had, and that she definitely wasn't a descendant of a First One and a magical alien cat.
Melog dropped toward the edge of a small lake, broke their fall with a few strong flaps of their wings, and touched down on the

ground. The rhythmic flow of a waterfall replaced the deafening winds of the sky.
Catra followed Melog toward the waterfall, thinking of the times she and Adora wandered through the Whispering Woods, silent but content in each other's company. The trees and the lake stood silently, letting the gentle roar of the waterfall fill the forest.
"A piece of our magic lies behind the water," Melog said. "When the kittens of our tribe were ready, they would come here to connect with it. It's one of the few sources of magic that survived both the First Ones and Prime's invasion. But the First Ones made a beast to guard our magic so that we could no longer access it as they stole it from us. I have not been able to defeat the beast myself. But we can do it together."
Okay, another big monster to fight. Nothing new. She thought about calling Adora to get some She-Ra backup, but if Melog thought they could do it on their own, she trusted them. Besides, it seemed like a nice bonding exercise.
"With the beast defeated, you can connect with our magic just as the kittens used to," Melog said. They turned to look straight into Catra's eyes, and she noticed how their eyes looked deep enough to hold universes. "I know you doubt your connection to this place, Catra. But if you touch our magic, you will see it for yourself."
Catra still couldn't bring herself to believe in the fairy tale Melog had told her. She could see herself defeating the beast, touching the planet's magic - whatever that looked like - only to have to tell Melog that it was all a mistake, she was just an Etherian with cat ears, she wasn't special.
She looked into Melog's eyes and saw their longing - felt their longing. They didn't just want to defeat the beast guarding their magic, they wanted to share their culture with someone. They wanted to share it with her. Catra sighed, thinking of how she would end up disappointing Melog. But she at least had to try.
"Okay," she said simply and turned to the waterfall. She saw Melog grow until they stood just taller than her. They crouched their head down, and Catra climbed onto their back, still surprised at how easily she trusted this creature. Melog took off in a sprint. Catra's fur stood up as they went under the waterfall, and she saw

Melog's do the same. She shook the water off and opened her eyes to see only darkness. The sound of the waterfall faded into the sound of Melog's feet running across rock, its echo making the quiet of the tunnel all the more eerie.

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They made their way back to the skimmer, back to the Fright Zone, and back to their bunker in silence. Catra held on to her anger at Adora long after she'd realized it was irrational. Her mind bounced between replaying the scene of her yelling at Adora and the thunderstorm of questions and emotions she still had about where she came from. In its absence, she found that she had held a sliver of hope in the first couple hours of their journey. But her hope was gone now, and she could tell Adora felt the same.

She watched Adora crawl into her bed and turn away from her. She wanted to curl up at the foot of Adora's bed and fall asleep to her familiar warmth, but she climbed up to her own bunk. Just as she pulled her covers over her head, she fell.

Adrenaline rushed through her body as she fell five feet through the air, then slammed into steel.

"Hello, Catra," said a voice that slithered through the air like a snake.

"Shadow Weaver," she said, rushing to stand to attention. Her eyes darted around. She was still in the Fright Zone, but she had never seen this room before: it was small, circular, and screens filled the wall behind her. The air was warm, and the smell of electrical fire surrounded her and lifted every hair on her body. But what drew her attention was the massive black rock in its center that buzzed with electricity. Shadow Weaver stood in front of it, her back to Catra.

"Did you enjoy your night out?" Shadow Weaver asked, condescension dripping from each word.

"I-H-How did you-" was all Catra managed. She felt her breath becoming short again.

"I see everything, Catra." She turned to face the child. "I understand you wish to find where you come from. You wish to find others like you."

Catra wasn't sure if she was supposed to reply to that, so she nodded. She pulled in deep, shaking breaths.

“Sneaking out to explore all of Etheria one night at a time is a fool’s errand that will only get you killed.” Shadow Weaver said. Shadows swept across the walls of the room and the floor beneath Catra until the child was surrounded by blackness, seeing only Shadow Weaver’s mask looming above her.
“And you put Adora in danger,” she hissed, letting Catra know this was her greatest sin. “I expect better from both of you.” Shadow Weaver stood, pausing a moment for Catra’s shame to sink in. The shadows retreated into Shadow Weaver’s body.
“Would you like to know where you come from, Catra?” Shadow Weaver’s voice had changed from terrifying to motherly in an instant.
Catra blinked away the tears in her eyes. She tried to speak but could not pause her desperate breathing long enough to form words. She nodded.
“You come from nowhere,” Shadow Weaver said. “The Horde found you alone. Nobody else like you exists on Etheria.”
Each word echoed a hundred times in Catra’s mind until they slurred together. She blinked away more tears and replanted her feet before she lost her balance.
Shadow Weaver knelt to look straight into Catra’s eyes. “Do not cry, Catra. You do not need people like you.”
She put her hand on the child’s cheek and wiped a tear with her thumb. “And besides, if you did find your people—your family—do you think they would want you?”
This time her words did not echo, but only hung in the air. Catra knew the answer, and it felt like a weight that pushed her body into the floor. Tears streamed down Catra’s face, even as she fought to keep them in.
“I have seen you in training, Catra. You always find victory through your own strength, you have never needed anyone. If you continue to excel in your training, you will be a fine Force Captain one day. The Horde is your home.”
Shadow Weaver stood as if she had done all a mother could do for her child. With a flick of her hand, a portal appeared that led straight to Catra’s bed. “Now then, you’d best get back to bed. You’ll have to be up soon for training.” The words fluttered from her mouth like banter.

Catra squeezed her eyes shut and clenched her shaking jaw. The tears stopped. She opened her eyes and walked through the portal like a ghost.

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Catra focused her eyes, her pupils dilated, and she started to see their surroundings. A tunnel of rock and earth surrounded them as the waterfall shrunk into nothingness. She felt her heart rate pick up as she looked ahead.

What is this beast like? If the magical, shape-shifting, teleporting, invisible alien cat can't defeat it, what help am I going to be?

She noticed Melog's mane was yellow, and she felt Melog's anxiety was as strong as her own. She was used to anxiety before a fight, but she usually just bottled it up and put on her confident persona until the adrenaline took over. But she knew Melog felt her anxiety as much as they felt their own, putting it in a bottle wouldn't work for them.

A green light shined ahead of them, and the tunnel widened out into a cavern. Melog slowed down and dropped Catra off their back as they approached the light. It came from a large green crystal that sat atop a giant head, and Catra followed it down to see a body that went on and on like a snake 20 meters in diameter.

Catra felt her and Melog become invisible, but she could still see Melog as an outline. Melog's mane turned into bright red spikes that blazed like a roaring fire. Catra looked ahead to see the monster shifting and rising until it was the size of a small building.

Okay, big scary monster, no big deal. It can't even see us. We got this. It'll be just like training in the Fright Zone with Adora.

The horrifying snake opened the mouth it didn't look like it had, and seven giant green tentacles came out, moving, ready to strike. Behind the tentacles sat rows and rows of sharp teeth lining its circular mouth all the way around. All the confidence Catra had mustered left her body. This was a lot worse than the Horde bots she fought in training.

Melog let out a vicious growl, and Catra's thoughts vanished. She pounced forward, running on all fours, driven only by adrenaline now, and ran to her right as she saw Melog taking the monster's other side. She saw the seven tentacles thrash out, lunging blindly

into all directions of the cave, making rock walls shake on impact. Catra dodged a tentacle, then closed the distance to the monster's body. She lunged into the air with a scream, claws out, ready to sink them into the monstrous snake's flesh-

And her claws scraped against metal. She slashed again at the creature's hull, only to see her claws drag against a metal coat. Few materials were immune to Catra's claws, and this was one of them.

Fuck.

She felt air fly out of her lungs and a burning pain in her side, and realized in midair that she had been hit by one of the tentacles. She crashed into rock and fell to the ground. Without thinking, she put her right foot on the ground and pushed off her knee until she was standing. She saw her legs tremble - she wasn't invisible anymore - and managed to take a painful breath before leaping out of the way of another tentacle, and another, and another, her entire body igniting with pain as she moved on reflex alone. She landed on her feet and felt a tentacle grab her, and before she could react, she was lifted into the air. It wrapped around her legs and arms before she could try to move them until all she could do was scream as she saw the horrifying swarm of tentacles and teeth getting closer and closer.

And then, an outline moved against the wall, and Melog slashed open the green crystal that lay at the center of the beast's head. The tentacle released, and Catra fell to her feet as the monster reeled back, let out a thunderous scream, and slammed its head into the wall.

Catra tried to take a few breaths, knowing she only had moments before she had to move again, but she had to see if her body could keep going. She stood up and moved her body through the pain. She'd been hit with worse and kept fighting. She turned to Melog and saw the flames in their mane still rippling with energy.

"Hey ugly!" Catra yelled with all the confidence she could muster. The gross cluster of tentacles and teeth turned towards her. Perfect. It struck her at that moment that she was trusting Melog was on the same page about a plan neither of them had said a word about. She jumped away just as a tentacle came crashing towards her, planting itself into the rock where she was standing

half a second ago. She looked up to see Melog soar through the air and meet the tentacle teeth first, clawing at it with the ferocity of pure instinct.
Three seconds of clawing and gnashing later, the tentacle snapped in half in a shower of green blood. The monster's screams filled the cave like a baby's cries hooked up to an amplifier, followed by the crash of the severed tentacle on the ground. Catra and Melog shared a glance before the beast turned toward them again, its six remaining tentacles still hovering around its face in an animalistic display of force.
"You missed me!" She hadn't mustered that kind of wit since her days of fighting Adora, and even with her body aching, she felt the stress of the battle ease now that she was having fun with it.
She leaped out of the way just in time. She jumped again and felt another tentacle graze her tail as she flew back on all fours, her mind back in adrenaline-fueled panic. She looked up and jumped again, this time landing on her back only inches away from the third tentacle that had almost killed her. Too close.
The monster screamed again as Melog bit through the first tentacle that came down at Catra. Inspired, she grabbed onto the second tentacle just as it flew off the ground. She clawed her way up the slimy trunk as it writhed up and down. She planted her claws into it. For a few seconds Catra let out the adrenaline-fueled rage that could only be found in the heat of a fight, the fury she always felt but learned to suppress so she could stay focused, the chaos she always pushed down in her fights with Adora, until her claws blurred in front of her and she felt them cut through the last fiber of the tentacle. Another scream ripped through the cave as she and the severed tentacle fell to the ground.
She landed with her feet and left hand planted in a triangle, her right hand raised in the air, still ready to strike. She allowed herself a few breaths. Three down, four to go.
The monster laid two tentacles on one wall of the cave and two on the other, and pulled them to each other, sweeping the floor of the cave with walls of green mass that were too tall for Catra to jump over. Catra panicked, every fiber in her body told her to move but she had no idea where.
She heard a familiar growl and saw Melog's outline running to her.

She jumped onto Melog's back at just the right time, trusting them with her life without a second thought. Melog leaped over the wall of tentacles closing in on them and landed with a skid. That was too easy, Catra heard her mind say. She turned around to see a tentacle wrap itself around Melog's legs. She gripped onto their fur as they both fell, then rose, and then moved through the air like they were on a conveyor belt that led to a pit of teeth and death.

Catra got a full view of the violent death that awaited them as she dangled in the air, her arms stretched up, still clinging to Melog's fur with an iron grip. The circles of teeth contracted and expanded as if the monster was taking deep breaths.

Think, Catra. They were getting closer. Think! She was still fixated on the teeth and tentacles that took up more and more of her view. She noticed then that the circle of teeth was outside the cluster of tentacles coming from its mouth.

Why would the teeth be outside? Does it normally retract its tentacles before chewing? Maybe the teeth are just for show. But maybe…

She had to try it. She pulled herself up Melog's body, hearing them wince as she pulled on their fur. Her muscles were on fire. She clawed her way up the tentacle wrapped around Melog's legs, started running, sprinting down its length, towards the pit that was waiting to swallow them…

And jumped in. She gasped in air, closed her eyes, and held her breath. She felt the slimy cluster of tentacles greet her, and blindly pulled herself deeper into the creature's mouth. She swung her right hand up, scratching across the roof of the beast's mouth. She heard another scream, this one making her ears ring, and then the sound of slicing as the monster's instincts brought teeth down into flesh. She felt herself falling before hitting the ground with a BOOM. The tentacles around her broke the fall, but it still knocked out the breath she was holding in her lungs.

She opened her eyes to see blackness all around her. The ringing in her ears seemed to climb higher and higher in pitch. She felt at least one tentacle on top of her. She tried to push it off and realized she couldn't breathe. She felt her head pulse, her torso convulse, then she was still.

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“The Horde blockade will have visual on us soon,” Entrapta said as she watched indecipherable holograms from Darla’s control deck.
“This better work,” Bow said.
“Only one way to find out,” Adora replied from the captain’s chair.
Catra stood at the deck with Entrapta and Melog, looking out at a beautiful expanse of stars - and the army of Horde ships waiting for them in the distance.
“You ready Melog?” she asked her feline friend. Melog bowed their head, became invisible, and the ship filled with the shining light of magic surrounding them. Catra looked back at all her new friends - Adora, Bow, Glimmer, Entrapta, and Wrong Hordak - they were all trusting her with their lives. She was equally proud of herself and terrified.
The magic in the air turned green. Catra looked to Adora in a panic, and saw the entire ship and everyone in it was washed in the shade of green she could never forget. She turned around again and saw the Horde blockade was now surrounding them, an army of ships that all seemed to be pointing right at her.
“What’s happening?” she muttered. She stepped backward and hit something, and turned to see Horde Prime standing inches from her, his face glooming down from above with the smug smile he always wore.
“Y-you can’t be here,” she stammered. She noticed her legs shake as she backed away from him.
“Oh, I’ve always been here,” Prime said in a voice that made every line sound rehearsed. She backed into something again and turned to see another Prime standing behind her, then a circle of Primes surrounded her, all looking down at her with the same smile.
“Your mind is such a fascinating place,” they all said in unison. “So much anger, so much pain…why would I ever leave it?”
Catra reached to the back of her neck. She felt Prime’s chip in the back of her neck, which made her vision go blurry as her heart pounded through her chest. She looked down and saw the white outfit Prime had put on her when he took over her mind - the outfit she had desperately clawed at to get off after Adora rescued her. After she thought Adora rescued her.

It was all just one of his games….
Catra bolted, shoving between two Primes with all her strength, moving on pure adrenaline. She ran across the bridge, opened the door - and saw Adora, Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta waiting for her.
“It’s Prime-he’s here,” she blurted out, gasping for breath.
“Of course he’s here,” Entrapta said. “He’s been in your mind this whole time.”
Catra started crying without knowing why. “You have to help me,” she said.
“Why would we help you?” Bow asked. “After everything you’ve done?”
“I-I thought-“ Catra sputtered.
“You thought what?” Glimmer spat at her. “You thought that you could do one good thing and erase all the pain you’ve caused? You thought we would just forget about everything you’ve done to us?”
Adora stepped forward until she was inches away from Catra. Her face was flat, her eyes showed more disappointment than anger.
“Why would I ever forgive you?” she asked. “After all the times you’ve made me suffer?”
Adora pushed her, and she fell back into the pool of green fluid. She swam, not knowing which way was up or down. She felt fluid seep into the chip in the back of her neck.
She broke free. She pulled herself out of the pool and ran, her mind and body on fire.
She was in an empty hallway. Glimmer teleported in front of her, staff raised.
“It’s time you pay for what you’ve done, Catra,” she said.
Catra’s body jumped ahead of her mind. She was watching herself from a distance now, seeing herself lunge at Glimmer, dodge her staff, wrap her arm around her neck, and lock Glimmer in a chokehold from behind. Her mind was a ghost now, watching her body move without her. She was wearing her red-and-black Horde jumpsuit, her hair in full mane.
“I’ve been wanting to do this for a long time,” Catra said as her claws shot out from her fingers.
No, don’t do it, don’t do it—
She watched herself sink her claws into Glimmer’s flesh, and blood

pooled onto the floor.
Catra took a punch to the head, and her head hit dirt. Her mind was back in her body now. She stood and looked around her - through the dust and smoke in the air she saw destroyed Horde tanks and bots, burning trees behind them, and the sounds of people screaming echoed behind her.
Adora emerged from the smoke. She wore her white Horde shirt, her face dirty and scarred, her hair falling out of its ponytail into a perfect mess on her shoulders. Catra remembered every detail perfectly. It was the day Adora left her.
Adora grabbed her by the throat and shoved her against a tank. She raised her sword until it touched Catra's chest. Catra had no desire to resist, she just looked at Adora through the haze.
"You…could've left," Adora said between breaths. She pushed the sword forward. Catra closed her eyes.
…….
She bolted upright and felt her chest heave in and out. Everything blurred as tears welled in her eyes.
She tried to take a deep breath in, but she lost control of the breath and she started heaving in and out faster. She focused on her exhales and breathed out a bit slower, then back in a bit slower, until she had slowed her breath to deep, shaking inhales and exhales.
Melog gently placed their head in her lap. She put her hand on their head and noticed how soft their fur felt between each finger. They stayed there for minutes or hours, unmoving except for the gentle scratches of Catra's hand, until the sounds of her breathing no longer filled the cavern and her heart accepted its confinement in her chest.
Catra finally snapped her head out of its fixed position of unfocused staring at the wall. She looked behind her and saw the body of the monstrous snake with a hole slashed into its head. Melog must have cut the beast open and pulled her out. It smelled like electricity and death.
Melog's mane was as tall as she was, mixing orange and yellow as it swayed in the air.
"That means you're worried," she said.
Melog sat up, not giving her an answer, and Catra turned to face

them.
"Look, this imprinting thing you did where we share each other's feelings….you have to undo it," she said.
Melog cocked their head, confused.
"That nightmare I had…I've had one like that every night since Adora rescued me. I feel like this all the time. And I can't control it. You shouldn't have to feel all of that too."
"Everything you feel now I have felt before," Melog said.
"Then you know how much it sucks! I can't put you through this." She heard her voice starting to break.
"Catra, after my planet fell, I spent decades in misery and guilt before I pulled myself out. I don't want the same thing to happen to you."
"Why are you helping me?" Catra spat. "Didn't you see enough of my past? I have done nothing but hurt and betray everyone who has trusted me."
"You are my people."
"Your people are dead!"
Catra pulled away from the words as soon as they left her mouth.
"I-I'm sorry," she said. "I know you want someone to share your home and your history with. But you're wrong about me. I'm not your people."
Melog stood and walked around the monster's body. Catra followed.
Cramped between the snake and the rock wall at the back of the cave was a small opening the size of a door. Melog sat outside it.
"Go in," they said.
Catra obliged.
She walked until she saw only black and heard only the echo of her steps. The door had vanished behind her, but she hoped Melog hadn't sent her to die alone in a cave—her comment was cruel, but it wasn't that cruel.
Still, she felt the familiar guilt budding inside her. She had let someone get close, and she had hurt them. This can't happen again.
Her mind returned to a fantasy imagined long ago. She was on a desolate planet, far from Etheria, far from Krytis, far from everyone. Maybe there were other creatures there, maybe there

weren't, but none of them knew her. She was a nomad, surviving on her own, and she never had to worry about hurting a soul. She had tried to hide how terrified she was to be around Adora again, and Entrapta, and Glimmer, and Bow. She was terrified to go back to Etheria, where Scorpia and everyone else she had hurt waited for her. She wanted to run from it all. And now she had hurt the first friend she had made since she was a child.

Her eyes adjusted at the whisper of light. A smell of something bright and warm danced into the air as Catra started running toward the soft blue light in front of her. It started to fill the tunnel as it widened out into a cave, and Catra saw the blue crystal nested into a pillar of rock as if it were on a throne of rock and dirt. It was long and jagged, and small enough to fit in her hand. She walked toward it, mesmerized.

"Hey, Catra," she heard. Every hair on her body shot up. The voice was too familiar.

She whipped around, and her heart jumped out of her chest. It was the voice she thought it was. She watched herself step out of the shadows into the faint blue light. Her hair was back in full mane, and she was dressed in her usual red and black outfit.

"Aww, did someone find a little princess rock?" she asked as if talking to a toddler.

Catra froze. Any confidence in her, real or fake, evaporated, her thoughts melted away, and her head throbbed as everything blurred around the other Catra.

"What's the matter," the cat asked with a smile. "Cat got your tongue?"

She giggled. Her outfit, her eyes, her hair, everything was exactly like the image she'd spent years seeing in the mirror.

"Try blinking, that might help," the cat said. "I get it, a lot of people get starstruck when they see me, but you don't have to be that weird about it."

She came face to face with Catra. "Come on, lighten up!" she said with a smile and poke to Catra's chest. "Let's get outta here and find you a wig to cover that awful haircut."

The poke sent Catra swaying back, and she stepped back to catch herself. She shook herself out of the trance.

"I-I'm taking the rock," Catra blurted out. Her voice was the same

as hers, only more awkward and terrified. Catra hated it.
"Why, so that you can be a magical princess? Come on Catra, I know you, and you know that this whole magic thing is bull. You're not magic, you never have been, don't lie to yourself and say there's a chance you are."
"I-I have to try," she said. "For Melog."
"Oh, you mean the magical alien you just met and immediately trusted? Why do you think they wanted you to go into a cave alone to take a magic rock you know nothing about?"
Catra felt her breaths become heavier.
"To see if I'm-"
"They're using you, Catra." The cat stepped behind her, and when Catra turned, she saw a white uniform, short hair, and solid green eyes.
"Or did you forget what happened last time someone crawled into your mind without asking?"
Catra reeled back at the sight of her body possessed. She remembered the green pool in front of her, the cold metal hands squeezing her arms, the sound of her screams as she felt needles sink into the back of her neck, and feeling her body move out of the pool while her mind stayed submerged.
"You don't trust people," the cat said before changing back to her previous look. Her voice sounded as confident and bold as it did in Catra's head but never out loud.
Catra blinked and forced herself back to the present.
"I'm not arguing with you," Catra said, trying to find some authority in her voice. "You're not real. You're just an illusion."
"No shit I'm an illusion," she said. "An illusion who's here to remind you who you are. Prime fucked up your brain and cut off your beautiful hair, but you are still Catra. You are the cat from nowhere who climbed her way to the top of the Horde. You have done everything in life on your own, and that's not going to stop now. You don't need Adora, you don't need her friends, and you don't need some alien who invaded your mind right after they met you."
The air seemed to run from Catra's breath. She had been backing away from the cat as she talked, and now she felt her back hit rock. The cat was inches from her now.

“Melog’s different,” Catra said.
“You don’t even believe that,” her other self said. She was right. “I’ve been whispering in your ear your entire life and you’ve always listened to me. When you were in your little depressed rut after Adora left it was my voice that pulled you out, it was my voice that got you to the top of the Horde, and it was my voice that’s kept you from getting hurt again. Why are you ignoring me now?”
For a moment they stood with eyes locked. Then Catra took a breath, and reminded herself how to speak.
“Because of Adora,” Catra said.
“It’s time to come out of the fantasy,” the cat said. Her words were softer, almost showing a hint of empathy. “You go back to Etheria and defeat Prime, but what then? People will realize your one good deed hardly stacks up against all the horrible shit you’ve done, and they’ll probably try to lock you up or kill you. Either way, Adora doesn’t stay with you. She probably only came back for you so she wouldn’t feel guilty about letting you die, or maybe she was still holding on to her ridiculous optimism that you’re a good person deep down. But after this is all over, she’ll sober up and realize you’ve never been the person she wanted you to be.”
Catra held her gaze. The cat put her hand on Catra’s shoulder, and Catra was shocked at the show of empathy.
“You were never going to have a life with Adora. You only have yourself, Catra. You always have.”
Emotion overtook her. She fell to the ground and cried, then wept. She accepted what she had spent the past week suppressing. Being forgiven was too good to be true, Adora would never stay with her, the voice in her head was right. Hope would only get her hurt.
She sat in the edges of the cavern that the light barely touched, across from herself, weeping until she was empty.
“Come on,” the cat said as she stood. “It’s time to go.”
Catra looked at her with clear eyes. She remembered her. She remembered seeing that face and hair and outfit every day while she hunted for Adora. She remembered hating how frizzy her hair got after a night without sleep. She remembered all the nights she lay in bed wanting to cut and kill the cat that stood in front of her

now.
She had purged her soul of hope, and now anger took its place. She stood
"You're wrong," she said.
"I don't think you're good at giving context," the cat replied, condescension back in her voice.
"It wasn't always just me. I used to have Adora. And I lost her because of you."
"Because of us."
"No," Catra said. Her claws shot out. "Because of you."
She threw her arm forward and felt her claws tear flesh. The cat reeled back and pressed her hand to a bloody face.
"Oh, there she is," the cat said with a laugh.
Catra heard that obnoxious laugh as the cat moved her hand to show crazed eyes and four scratches across her cheek. Catra saw it all now. She saw the cat in front of her swinging claws at Adora, kidnapping her friends, killing rebels. She saw the cat pulling the lever to open the portal that nearly destroyed reality. She saw the cat screaming at Scorpia, betraying Entrapta, and manipulating everyone around her. She saw her standing in a battlefield, walking away from her only friend. Every mistake that had turned her life into agony was because of her.
Catra lunged at her, then took a kick to the face that sent her back to the ground. The cat went for a kick, but Catra caught her leg and pulled her down, climbed on top of her, and slammed her head into the ground.
"You could've left," Catra said.
"She left us."
The cat slashed across Catra's exposed stomach and kicked her off of her. They both stood, arms up, claws out. Catra dodged the cat's first swing, the cat blocked her kick. They went on blocking and dodging every move that they both saw coming, trading a few scratches and blows.
They both realized what was happening at the same time, but Catra moved faster. She ducked under the cat's kick, pushed herself behind her, and yanked down hard on the cat's mane. She heard the cat's skull hit rock.
Catra straddled her and punched her across the face, then

punched her again, and again, and again. She screamed with all the air in her lungs. Her vision went red as she watched her own bruised and bloodied face knock back and forth, blood splattering with each blow. A part of her felt euphoria as she unleashed revenge disguised as justice.

She didn't notice claws slashing into her sides, and she didn't notice feet clamp her neck from behind and send her body flying backward.

The cat climbed on top of her. Catra swung her claws at her, but the cat caught her wrists and pinned them to the ground. Catra barely recognized herself: the cat's face was purple and blue, blood poured from the scratches on her cheek and the splits in her flesh. But she was still smiling. And then her head came down.

BOOM. BOOM. BOOM.

Catra felt her head collide between the other Catra's forehead and the rock beneath her three times. Her vision went black. A deafening ring came from all around her. She forced her eyes open and saw a blurry vision of herself still smiling. She saw the cat's head go back, then come toward her again.

Catra pulled her arms free and threw them forward, and felt the claws on her thumbs pierce straight through the cat's neck.

They held each other's eyes for a moment. Blood ran down Catra's thumbs and forearms.

"You're a monster," Catra whispered.

"I'm you," the cat hissed back.

She smiled again, then sent her head crashing down.

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Catra's eyes shot open. She saw blue, then she heard water, then she felt the water touching every hair of her body. She spasmed and waved her arms frantically before teeth clamped down on her neck and pulled her out.

Melog dropped her on the lake's shore, and Catra felt dirt and leaves stick to her wet body as she gasped for air.

It came back to her in pieces. She remembered her other self, her smile, her laugh, her blood splattering across rock, the smile across her broken face as she sent her forehead crashing into Catra's nose.

Then it all came back like an ocean crashing on top of her. She felt her head pound, her heart race, the air in her lungs escape her. Melog pressed their head into Catra's chest. She felt her heart pound against their head. She drank in her breaths. She put a hand on Melog's fur and tried to focus on the orange leaves dancing above her.

They laid like that for minutes or hours, until Catra's breath slowed and she no longer felt her heartbeat thumping into Melog's head.

She put a hand to her stomach, the cuts and bruises were gone. Just an illusion.

Her comm beeped in her ear, reminding her it was still there. She sat up and tapped it.

"Hey! Catra! It's Adora. You probably figured that out from the voice. Bow's got Darla up and running, so just, uh, wondering how much longer you'll be…"

Hearing Adora's voice sent her back to everything the cat had said about her. She couldn't think about that now.

"Hey Adora. I just need a little more time. We'll be back soon."

"Okay, no rush! I mean, kind of a rush, since ya know, Horde Prime is taking over Etheria and we might be the only hope for our planet's survival…but take your time!"

Catra heard her comm turn off and let out a sigh. She turned to Melog.

"Why are you helping me?" she asked again. "I'm not your people. You just met me. And I didn't connect with the magic down there."

Melog stared into her eyes, thinking.

"After Prime destroyed my home and my people, I spent decades obsessed with him," Melog said. "I mourned the loss of my family by searching for revenge. Every day I relived my battle with him, every day I felt guilty, angry, alone. We imprinted because our stories align. I saw my life in yours. I saw my pain and guilt and grief in you."

"How'd you get out of it?" Catra asked.

Melog thought for a while longer.

"One day, I remembered memories I had forgotten. I remembered playing with my parents and my siblings. I remembered all the

times I had felt happy here. I had so much love for my home and yet I was so angry that I only remembered the tragedy. Once I remembered everything for what it was, the anger just…fell away."
Catra paused, not sure what to say.
"You know I don't deserve your help," she said. "You've seen how much pain I've caused."
"And I see who you are now. You have grown beyond your mistakes."
Catra turned away from them. She remembered the image of her other self on the ground, her own fists covered in blood.
"I don't know who I am now," she mumbled.
Catra stood and looked at the waterfall. "Why her?" she asked.
"Cats are defined by our loyalty," Melog said. "The stone shows you whoever you are most loyal to."
Catra took a step back.
"No. That's not true. I'm — I'm not loyal to her. I hate her," she said.
"Hatred and loyalty are closer than you think, Catra," Melog said. "I was loyal to Prime for the decades I spent hating him. I did not serve him, but I let him control me."
"Y-you're wrong," Catra spat without believing her words. "I'm going back."
"Why?" Melog asked.
"I have to end this."
Catra marched off into the waterfall.
.....
Adora spent three minutes curled in fetal position, her eyes squeezed shut, begging for sleep to put her mind to rest. She tried to ignore Catra's bed squeaking above her.
She heard a sniff, the sniff of Catra trying to stay silent while crying. She spent a minute debating whether or not she should check on her, thinking of all the reasons she had to ignore Catra and let her work her own problems out for once. She came to the conclusion that she would never sleep if she didn't go up.
Adora climbed up to Catra's bed and found her curled in a ball facing away from her. Adora lay next to her, trying to keep her face out of Catra's mane.

“I’m sorry I got mad at you,” Catra said. She rolled onto her back and stared at the ceiling. Her words were flat but Adora knew she meant them. She was surprised Catra spoke first and doubly surprised to hear her apologize. Something was really wrong with her.
“Shadow Weaver told me everything,” Catra said. “I don’t have people. I don’t have a family. I’m just…alone.”
Catra’s eyes looked hollow. Adora could see she had already accepted it.
“I’m so sorry, Catra,” Adora said. She reached around Catra and pulled her close, letting her face get lost in the mane.
“But you do have people. You have me.”
Catra wept again when she felt Adora’s warmth and her arms wrapped around her, until sleep took them both.
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Catra’s eyes stayed fixed on the end of the tunnel, and her thoughts filled its silence. She thought of every move the cat would make, every weakness that only she knew, every attack the cat wouldn’t see coming.
Her claws slid out unconsciously as she replayed the battle in her mind, seeing her own face in red, the smile, the laugh, every detail making her blood boil. She had to be free of her. Ending her would end the torture she had been living through. She spent years justifying her actions to herself every day and hating herself every night, suppressing what she knew of herself, that she was a monster. She finally accepted who she was when she chose to save Glimmer, and the weight of it would have crushed her if she’d known she’d have to live with it. But she didn’t think she would. She could save Glimmer and Prime would give her a martyr’s death. She could have peace.
But then Adora saved her. And now she was subjected to living, knowing she deserved death. But now the magic of Krytis had given her the chance to enact justice on herself without worrying about what it would do to Adora.
She reached the chasm and walked past the fallen snake without a second glance. She walked through the tunnel until she saw blue light.
“Come back for more?” She heard the cat before she saw her. “Or

did you come to tell me I was right?”
She saw her leaning against the pillar that held the blue rock.
“I’m taking the rock,” Catra said in her most authoritative voice.
The cat pushed herself off the pillar and backed away. “Okay,” she said. “All yours.”
Catra stood still and kept her eyes on the cat. A grin crawled across the cat’s face.
“But that’s not really why you’re here, is it?”
It wasn’t a question. Catra didn’t answer. She slid her right foot back, raised her arms, and watched the cat do the same. She pounced forward and leaped over the cat’s kick, grabbed her by the mane, and pulled her head into the ground. She feinted a kick to the face, then grabbed both of the cat’s arms as she raised them to block. She dug her claws into flesh and heaved as she pulled the cat off the ground, over her head, and slammed her body into rock.
The cat sprung back to her feet and swung at Catra. Catra caught one wrist, then the other, then brought her forehead into the cat’s nose. The cat reeled back and held her bleeding face. Catra swung again, but the cat ducked and sent her knee through Catra’s stomach. It was an attack she had never done before, completely out of style. She’s caught on.
The cat pounced on her moment of confusion, kicking Catra’s stomach and slashing across her face. Catra forgot strategy and tackled the cat to the ground. She closed her eyes and screamed as claws flew, then felt a punch to the face send her body falling to the ground. The cat grabbed both of her ears and screamed as she pulled Catra’s nose into her skull.
Catra’s head slammed into rock. She watched the cat roll off her with blurred vision Her brain pounded inside her skull.
Catra heard that maniacal laugh again, her eyes focused, her vision became crisp, and she pounced without a thought. She slammed the cat into the wall behind her and started slashing, punching, dodging, running on instinct alone. Arms and claws blurred as the cats exchanged blows.
The cat kicked Catra’s breath out of her body, sending her back into the pillar of rock that held the faint blue rock lighting the space. The cat punched a tooth out of Catra’s mouth. She swung

her claws at Catra, but Catra caught the cat's hand, grabbed her middle finger, and bent it backward.
She heard bones snap, and then the cat's scream as she fell to her knees. Catra kicked her square across the face, sending her back into the ground.
Catra straddled her just as she had earlier. She looked down at her trophy. The fur on her face was matted with blood, her nose bent upwards, her cheeks swollen.
Catra punched her hard across her left cheek. She watched her head fly to the left and a spurt of blood fly from her mouth.
The image called a memory from years before. She remembered seeing that image in the mirror of the Fright Zone bathroom on the night that Adora left her, and the night after she opened the portal, and the night Scorpia left her.
She punched the cat again. Her eyes showed she accepted defeat. They were the same eyes she saw in the mirror.
Catra saw herself in the mirror, blood dripping from her mouth, raising her fist for another blow. You deserve this, she told herself then and now.
She closed her eyes. Her breath became short, and she started gasping for breath as she held her fist in the air. She opened her eyes and saw the cat staring back at her. Her eyes were hollow.
She dropped her arm. She breathed for another moment, her breath still feeling heavier than her body. She moved off of the cat.
They stayed there for a few minutes, the cat laying with her eyes on the ceiling and Catra sitting with her eyes on the floor. They barely blinked. The sound of breath filled the cavern, and after a minute their breathing fell in sync.
The cat sat up. She kept her eyes on the ground for a moment before looking Catra in the eyes.
Neither had any words. Catra lifted her hands awkwardly, as if trying to find a thought drifting in the air, then she leaned forward and wrapped her arms around the cat. They sat there for a moment, their eyes wide and breath heavy. The feeling of physical contact was strange to Catra; she knew it was even more off-putting for her younger self.
"I'm sorry she left," Catra finally said.

When she finally pulled away, the cat was gone, and Adora took her place. She wore the same ponytail, blue eyes, and endearing smile. Catra felt tears well inside her, but she didn't cry.
Adora stood and offered Catra her hand. Catra took it, and they both held on after Adora pulled her up.
"Come on," Adora said.
She pulled Catra to the pillar, and they both looked up at the shining blue rock.
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The waterfall drenched Catra's fur, and sunlight blinded her eyes when she opened them. She walked to Melog, still sitting patiently beside the lake, and hugged them. She couldn't remember the last time she had hugged someone, and now she had given two hugs in one day.
"Thank you," she said when she pulled away.
"Did you see what you needed?" Melog asked.
"Yeah," she said. "I touched the rock. It felt…familiar, but in a distant sort of way. I don't know."
Melog cocked their head and said nothing.
"I'm sorry," Catra blurted out. She became aware of how awkward her voice sounded. "I know you feel what I feel and I just felt a lot of awful stuff and I don't want you to feel all that and I'm trying to work on my anger issues but it's really hard—"
Her words were tripping over themselves. Melog pressed their head into Catra, gentler than they had before. Catra put a hand to their forehead, breathed, and blinked away the tears forming.
"It's okay," Melog whispered. "It's okay."
Catra remembered hearing Adora whisper those words to her when they were children.
Melog raised their head, and Catra scratched behind their ears. They closed their eyes and purred. She made a mental note of that spot.
"You wanna get out of here?" She asked.
Melog nodded. Catra closed her eyes and took a deep breath, preparing to return to Adora, and everyone else, and the mission, putting the last few hours in a mental box to return to later. She opened her eyes and put her hand on Melog.
Catra felt her stomach flip upside down, her throat fold in on

itself, and whatever she didn’t throw up earlier came up now.
“Catra! Are you okay?” Adora’s voice cried out as she ran to Catra’s side.
Catra pushed herself off her knees and spat on the ground. She felt dizzy and nauseous, but at least it sobered her from feeling emotional.
“I don’t know how Glimmer does that all day,” she croaked out.
Adora wrapped her arms around Catra and squeezed the air out of her lungs. To both their surprise, Catra squeezed her just as tight in return.
“Come on,” Adora said after they fell apart.
They walked toward the ship.
“Sooooo are you going to tell me all about your adventure?” Adora asked.
Catra looked at Melog, watching their blue mane flow through the air.
“Yeah…one day,” Catra said.

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